Chicken Little

By James Finn Garner

CHICKEN LITTLE: **(Pg 57-62)** *(happily playing in the road)*

NARRATOR: Chicken Little lived on a winding country lane surrounded by tall oak trees. (It should be mentioned here that the name "Little" was a family name, and not a derogatory, size-biased nickname. It was only by sheer coincidence that Chicken Little was also of shorter-than-average height.) One day, Chicken Little was playing in the road when a gust of wind blew through the trees. An acorn was blown loose and hit Chicken Little squarely on the head.

CHICKEN LITTLE: *(squawking and spinning in circles)*

INTRODUCTION

Ladies and gentlemen, esteemed members of the jury, and anyone who has ever stubbed their toe and briefly considered suing the furniture . . . welcome! Today's selection is not just a story. It's a legal drama; a barnyard thriller, if you will.

*You may **think** you know the story of Chicken Little -- the tale of (pardon my alliteration) panic, paranoia, and poultry? But think again! In this version, the sky isn't just falling…it's **liable**. And someone's getting paid. When Chicken Little gets bonked on the head, it's not just a crisis; it's a lawsuit!*

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NARRATOR: Now, while Chicken Little had a small brain in the physical sense, she did use it to the best of her abilities. So when she screamed . . .

CHICKEN LITTLE: The sky is falling, the sky is falling!

NARRATOR: . . . her conclusion was not wrong or stupid or silly, only logically under enhanced. Chicken Little ran down the road until she came to the house of her neighbor, Henny Penny, who was tending her garden. This was a simple task, since she didn't use any insecticide, herbicide or fertilizer, and also permitted the native nonedible varieties of wildflower (sometimes branded "weeds") to mingle with her food crops. So, lost amid the foliage, Henny Penny heard Chicken Little's voice long before she saw her.

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CHICKEN LITTLE: The sky is falling! The sky is falling!

HENNY PENNY: *(sticking her head out from her garden)* Chicken Little! Why are you carrying on so?

CHICKEN LITTLE: I was playing in the road when a huge chunk of the sky fell and landed on my head. See? Here's the bump to prove it.

HENNY PENNY: There's just one thing to do.

CHICKEN LITTLE: What's that?

HENNY PENNY: Sue the b**tards!

CHICKEN LITTLE: *(puzzled)* Sue for what?

HENNY PENNY: Personal injury, discrimination, intentional infliction of emotional distress, negligent infliction of emotional distress, tortuous interference, the tort of outrage -- you name it, we'll sue for it.

CHICKEN LITTLE: Good gracious! What will we get for all of that?

HENNY PENNY: We can get payment for pain and suffering, compensatory damages, punitive damages, disability and disfigurement, long-term care, mental anguish, impaired earning power, loss of esteem . . .

CHICKEN LITTLE: *(joyfully)* Person, oh, person! Who are we going to sue?

HENNY PENNY: Well, I don't think the sky ***per se*** is recognized as a suable entity by the state.

CHICKEN LITTLE: *(her diminutive brain working overtime)* I guess we should go find a lawyer and learn who is suable.

HENNY PENNY: That's a good idea. And while we're there, I can ask whom to sue for these ridiculously bony legs of mine. They've caused me nothing but anguish and embarrassment my whole life and I should be compensated somehow for all that.

NARRATOR: So, they ran farther down the road until they came to the house of their neighbor, Goosey Loosey. Goosey Loosey was busy teaching her canine animal companion to eat grass so she could avoid the guilty feelings that came with feeding the dog processed animal carcasses from a can.

CHICKEN LITTLE: The sky is falling! The sky is falling!

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HENNY PENNY: Sue the b**tards! Sue the b**tards!

GOOSEY LOOSEY: *(leaning over her fence)* Land sakes! Why are you two carrying on so?

CHICKEN LITTLE: I was playing in the road and a piece of sky fell on my head.

HENNY PENNY: So we're going to find a lawyer to tell us whom we can sue both for her injuries and for my bony legs.

GOOSEY LOOSEY: Oh good! Can I come and sue someone for my long, gangly neck? You know, nothing really flatters it, so I am convinced there's a conspiracy within the fashion industry against long-necked waterfowl.

NARRATOR: So, the three of them ran down the road looking for legal assistance.

CHICKEN LITTLE: The sky is falling! The sky is falling!

HENNY PENNY: Sue the bastards! Sue the bastards!

GOOSEY LOOSEY: Smash the conspiracy! Smash the conspiracy!

NARRATOR: Farther down the road they met Foxy Loxy, who was dressed in a blue suit and carried a briefcase. He held up a paw to halt the entourage.

FOXY LOXY: And what are you three doing out on this lovely day?

ALL TOGETHER: We're looking for someone to sue!

FOXY LOXY: What are your grievances? Personal injury? Discrimination? Intentional infliction of emotional distress? Negligent infliction of emotional distress? Tortious interference? The tort of outrage?

CHICKEN LITTLE: *(excitedly)* Oh, yes, yes!

GOOSEY LOOSEY: all that . . .

HENNY PENNY: . . .and more!

FOXY LOXY: Well, then, you're in luck. My caseload has just eased up, so I will be able to represent you in any and all lawsuits we can manage to bring.

CHICKEN LITTLE: *(cheering and flapping her wings)* But who are we going to sue?

FOXY LOXY: *(without missing a beat)* Who ***aren't*** we going to sue? Three hapless victims such as yourselves will be able to find more guilty parties than you can shake a writ at. *(deviously)* Now, let's all step into my office so we can discuss this further.

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NARRATOR: Foxy Loxy walked over to a small black metal door that was in the side of a small hill nearby.

FOXY LOXY: *(trying to lift the latch)* Step right this way.

NARRATOR: But the black door wouldn't open.

FOXY LOXY: *(tugging on it with one paw, then with both. It still wouldn't budge. He yanks and pulls violently, cursing the door, its mental abilities, and its history)* *Insert random tirade*

NARRATOR: Finally, the door swung open, and a huge ball of fire shot out.

FOXY LOXY: *(screams and tries to dodge)*

NARRATOR: This was really the door to Foxy Loxy's oven! But unfortunately for him, the ball of fire engulfed his head, burned off every hair and whisker, and left him totally catatonic.

FOXY LOXY: *(babbles incoherently)*

NARRATOR: Chicken Little, Henny Penny, and Goosey Loosey ran away, thankful that they had not been devoured.

However, the ***family*** of Foxy Loxy caught up with them. In addition to suing the manufacturer of the oven door on behalf of Foxy Loxy, the family brought suit against the three barnyard fowl: Chicken Little, Henny Penny and Goosey Loosey, claiming entrapment, reckless endangerment, and fraud. The family sought payment for pain and suffering, compensatory damages, punitive damages, disability and disfigurement, long-term care, mental anguish, impaired earning power, loss of esteem, and the loss of a good dinner.

The three birds later brought a countersuit, and they've all been battling in court from that day to this.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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